

Chapter 105-5

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When Xu Qingzhu said she would coax Liang Shi, she took her upstairs to eat at a famous devilishly spicy hotpot restaurant.

Liang Shi couldn't really handle spicy food. When they entered the restaurant, she teased: "Is this coaxing me or coaxing yourself?"

"Coaxing you, of course," Xu Qingzhu said shamelessly.

They followed the server inside. Every table had a bright red soup base. No one came here to eat any other flavor, and many people's lips had turned a vivid red from the spiciness.

But when they reached their seats and the server handed them the menu, Xu Qingzhu said: "I want a dual-flavor soup base."

Before the server could say they didn't have dual-flavor soup bases, Xu Qingzhu continued: "One mushroom broth, one tomato."

Server: "?"

"I'm sorry, miss. We only have three flavors here: numbing spicy, extra spicy, and super spicy. If you want a dual-flavor, you can only pair it with a plain water base." The server patiently explained.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, her eyes clear, and said in a very polite tone: "But my wife can't eat spicy food. I want her to have these two flavors. Can you bring me two plain water bases and I'll cook it myself? I'll pay the full price."

The server was put in a difficult position—this was probably the first time she'd heard such a request.

However, it wasn't too difficult to accommodate. The server placed an order for two plain water bases and didn't charge her for them.

Xu Qingzhu ordered some dishes. After the server left, Liang Shi asked her in confusion: "Why come to a place that specializes in spicy food but not eat spicy, and make other requests instead?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't explain, only saying: "Wait for me five minutes."

Then she got up and left, walking past table after table of bright red hotpots.

Five minutes later, Xu Qingzhu returned with an instant mushroom soup base packet and tomato hotpot seasoning. She tore open the packaging and poured both packets into the pot.

Their table immediately stood out as completely out of place.

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu lowered her eyes, stirring the soup base with serving chopsticks. While waiting for the water to boil, she said to her: "You don't have to do certain things just because you're in a certain setting. Sometimes you can learn to break the rules."

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very soft.

Liang Shi looked at her through the misty steam. The hotpot restaurant was filled with spicy aromas, but only their table gave off the scent of mushroom soup and tomato—one milky white, one scarlet red. Everything was different from the surroundings.

Then Xu Qingzhu's voice sounded again: "People should be selfish. No matter how great you are, you shouldn't override human nature. Also, breaking rules and removing restraints feels really liberating. This is something I learned after dying once."

Liang Shi: "....."

She suddenly felt like the meal before her wasn't hotpot, but a pot of philosophy.

These two packets of hotpot seasoning had ascended to a higher plane right then and there.

Liang Shi put the plate of meat into the mushroom soup pot. "Others eat red while we eat white—that's actually pretty nice."

Xu Qingzhu smiled, then took the plate of meat from her hands and used the serving chopsticks to add it to the pot. "Don't move, I'll do it."

Liang Shi: "....."

For some reason, the scene from this morning suddenly appeared in her mind.

It was the same words, but it wasn't Xu Qingzhu who had said them.

At that time, it was Liang Shi who had said: "Don't move, I'll do it."

Xu Qingzhu also only realized after saying it that these words seemed a bit off, but she didn't try to fix it, letting Liang Shi's imagination run wild.

Liang Shi thought about it so much on her own that her ears turned red. The sensation on her hands seemed to still linger.

She pinched her earlobe, and then Xu Qingzhu's arm reached across the table to also pinch her earlobe.

Liang Shi looked at her. "What are you doing?"

Xu Qingzhu's slightly cool fingertips still carried some moisture. Hearing her question, she asked with a light laugh: "Teacher Liang, your ears are so red. What are you thinking about?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Her teasing tone made Liang Shi's ears turn even redder, and they were continuously reddening under her fingertips.

Her rubbing motion kept reminding Liang Shi of this morning's events, so Liang Shi pressed down on her hand. "Eat meat."

"Whose meat?" Xu Qingzhu replied without thinking.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi gritted her teeth secretly. "Yours."

Xu Qingzhu sat across from her, using the serving chopsticks to pick up a slice of meat for her. Through the misty steam, she smiled at her: "Which part?"

Liang Shi: "....."

This meal was really hard to get into her mouth.

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When they came out of the mall, it had started raining again outside.

It was as if the brief clear weather that afternoon had only been to let people go out for a walk. The pattering rain had dampened the entire city.

Quite a few people were trapped in the mall because they hadn't brought umbrellas.

Many people stood at the mall exit waiting for the rain to stop. There were young couples nearby hugging each other because it was too cold. Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi at most stood a bit closer together, each with their hands in their own pockets, as if they didn't know each other.

Liang Shi glanced several times at the young couples around them, then looked at the unmoved Xu Qingzhu. She didn't dare make any moves either.

Then someone nearby jostled them, pushing Xu Qingzhu directly toward Liang Shi. Liang Shi reached out to steady her.

The person apologized profusely. Xu Qingzhu replied distantly that it was fine.

Liang Shi steadied her and asked: "Are you okay?"

Xu Qingzhu straightened up but said: "Something's wrong."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu put her hand into Liang Shi's coat pocket. "My pocket is a bit cold."

A moment later, Liang Shi also put her hand back into her coat pocket, which happened to cover Xu Qingzhu's hand. Indeed, as she said, her coat pocket was too cold, so even her hand was cold.

Liang Shi smiled and said: "My pocket is warm."

"Are all Alphas this warm, or is it just you?" Xu Qingzhu asked casually.

Liang Shi shook her head. "I don't know. I've never held an Alpha's hand."

"So you've held an Omega's then?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "Do you count?"

"I count," Xu Qingzhu said definitively.

Neither of them spoke loudly—only loud enough for each other to hear. It was just the tone of casual chitchat.

The awkward argument from that afternoon seemed like it had never happened.

When the rain was about to stop, Liang Shi's phone rang. It was another unknown number.

After taking over the original host's phone that had no contacts saved, Liang Shi had gotten used to answering unknown numbers. She picked up and greeted politely: "Hello?"

All she heard from the other end was crying—a female voice.

The voice sounded somewhat familiar. After careful recognition, Liang Shi tentatively called out: "Wanwan?"

Liang Wanwan suddenly stopped, and between sobs, responded with an "mm."

Liang Shi immediately said: "What's wrong? Don't cry first. What happened?"

There was a pause on Liang Wanwan's end before she said: "Jie, I... I slapped Liang Xinran."